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Mike Vax

Mike Vax has led a distinguished career as a lead trumpet player, jazz clinician, and leader of multiple big bands, including The Stan Kenton Legacy Orchestra.

Mike was interviewed via Zoom on December 29, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very happy to have Mike Vax with me today. And you may not remember but we sort of saw each other 50 maybe 1 years ago.

MV: Really?

MR: Yeah 1971 or 2 at SUNY Fredonia.

MV: Oh of course. You know I've got to tell you I remember that whole thing very, very well. A guy that is still one of my close friends John Luebke was one of the Phi Mu Alpha people that got them to sponsor the Kenton band and we did a residency. I think we were there for like three days or something?

MR: That's correct.

MV: And I have to tell you, there's a great story — at one point we were doing a panel discussion, it was Stan and Dick Shearer and I. And they were talking about, you know, liking to have — some of the teachers were talking about, you know, having doctorates and all that. And Stan really started talking about how important it was that teachers, that musicians who knew how to teach that had been on the road, that really understood what the music business is like and what it's like to be a road musician. He said you know that's really important, in some ways it's more important than pieces of paper. And so this discussion went on and all of a sudden I got this brain thing, it's like it just came to me and this one teacher — and I mean I understand where they're coming from 'cause I taught in colleges with only a bachelor's. And so he's really on this thing about the doctorate stuff and I said, you know, "Wait a minute, I have an idea, I have an idea for a comparison. So have you ever done a lot of playing professionally? And he said, "Well no, I was working on my doctorate and I teach." And I said, "Well okay, I want to point something out to you. Would you like to have a brain surgery done by a doctor who was taught by a doctor who had never done brain surgery?" And I got this huge ovation from the students. I never forgot that.

MR: Aw, you know I think you have some nerve in a positive way. Because I was reading the thing, this beautiful thing you wrote recently on FaceBook and you said that in 1960 you went to the Second National Stage Band Camp and afterwards you went up to Stan Kenton and said, "I'm going to play lead trumpet in your band."

MV: Right. I did.

MR: And you were 17?

MV: I was 17 years old and it was interesting because in the earlier camps there were more older guys than high school guys so I was one of the younger guys and I think I made lead in about the third band out of twelve or something, you know, but Don Jacoby had been to my school and done a clinic at my high school. And he talked me into going to the camp but that summer he had a gum infection and he couldn't go so he called Conte Candoli and Jimmy Maxwell and said, "I want you to look out for my kid Mike." So I get there and I don't even remember my audition I was so scared. I mean that was my first time really away from home. And I'd taken a train from Oakland, California to Bloomington, Indiana and so I go in there and all I remember is Conte said, "Oh you're Jake's kid." So I did my audition, you know, and I did okay. But they needed a fourth trumpet player for the faculty band for the Kenton band. And so here I am this young kid and they put me in the band. So I got to play under Stan when I was 17. And I was going to get a degree in classical performance and I was going to be a symphony player. That's what I was planning on, although I loved jazz, but I was planning on being a symphony player. And that camp changed my whole outlook. Because playing on the Kenton band became the most important thing in my life that I wanted to do. And so at the end of the camp I did, I went up to Stan and I said, "I want to play lead trumpet in your band someday." And what he said changed my life because he said, "If you want to bad enough you probably will." And what I heard was Stan said, Stan Kenton said I can play on his band.

MR: So when you came — I'm sorry, go ahead.

MV: So for ten years between five years in college and four years in the Navy, you know, my whole goal was I've got to get on the Kenton band someday.

MR: When you came to Fredonia I think you probably were playing lead and you were the band manager, is that correct?

MV: Right. Yeah.

MR: So I want you to try a little scenario here. You have to write a description to put in a newspaper, a job opportunity: Lead Trumpet for Stan Kenton. And how do you describe that job succinctly?

MV: Well it's a lot of pressure. You know I mean and it's interesting that I was put on lead trumpet two days before the "Redlands" album. The lead trumpet player before me, Jim Kartchner, had a brain tumor and didn't know it and he was having all kinds of chop problems. And a few days before, you know "Redlands" was the first album on Creative World. I mean Stan was really nervous about this. You know it was the first album away from Capitol on his own label. And so Jim just said, "I don't want to mess up the album, I can't do it." And Stan's thinking well do I get Buddy Childers or do I get Al Porcino or

do I get — and some of the guys in the band said, "You know Vax can handle it." And so this is like two days before and I get called down to breakfast and Stan had been really nervous about this whole thing and was thinking about using big name guys from L.A. that had been on the band before. And Willie Maiden, rest his soul, said to Stan, "These young kids are playing your music as good as anybody ever has and if you use any ringers you can't record my music." He was adamant about, you've always used your road men, you don't need the studio guys. So they called me down, Stan and Dick Shearer called me down to breakfast and they're having small talk while at breakfast and I'm thinking you SOB's if you're going to fire me just do it. And I'm thinking I'm only the third trumpet player why am I getting fired? You know. And I remember at the end of the meal Stan had his coffee cup up and it stopped halfway down and he stares at me for what — it felt like an eon you know. And he says, I won't say the exact words, he says the trumpet section is really screwed up. And I'm thinking here it comes. And he said, the next thing out of his mind is, out of his mouth is, "Can you handle the lead book?" And I said, "Yeah I can handle the lead book." And he said, "Good, and it better be right when we start recording Monday night." Stan knew when people were ready for things, whether it was a lead player or a jazz player that hadn't been playing a lot of solos. Stan was just such a great leader. He knew when people were ready for things. So he knew that I was ready for it but he wanted me to say that I was ready for it. So you know I think that being a lead trumpet on any big band, maybe especially the Kenton band because the charts are so hard, but being the lead trumpet on any big band, you're sort of like the quarterback. You know? And the drummer is like the other quarterback or the halfback, which is as important as you are. You know. And the lead trumpet and the drummer have to just get right together. They just have to be there. And of course then the bass player comes in too because you're talking about the time of the band. So it's a lot of responsibility and it isn't so much high notes. You know all these people say, "Oh the lead trumpet player, they've got to play all these high notes." Maynard never played lead on the Kenton band. He played third trumpet and his book was the high note trumpet. Bud Brisbois did play some lead but a lot of the time on a lot of recordings he was the high note player and Dalton Smith was the lead trumpet player. So it's not only a matter of having high notes in a high register. It's a matter of can you play it exactly the same every single night? That's the important thing. The band is relying on the lead trumpet to set the stylistic approach, to set the articulations, to set time feel. And so there's a lot on your shoulders. And it's up to you. You have to know — what I say to the kids is the lead trumpet player is the least creative person on the band. You have to play it the same every single night whether you've played the chart ten times or a thousand times. You know you've got to put the energy in. You've got to make it, the audience feel

like yeah, this is really cool. And, but the consistency has to be there or the time has to be there, and the sound has to be right to carry over the band, you know, because a lot of times the lead trumpet has the melody. It's the responsibility.

MR: Did you ever have a circumstance, there's a chart and there's drum breaks or there's a drum solo of a specific length, 4 bars, 8 bars. And the drummer played something and people aren't sure where one is. And it's coming up and we've got to come back in. And do you take the reigns and say here's where it is?

MV: Well yes. But here's one thing I say to young drummers. I don't care if it's a fill or if it's a long solo or whatever it is, one is the most important thing and you had better lead the band in with what you're playing so that the band knows where to come in. And great drummers always do that. I don't care if it's a two-beat fill or if it's a 20-bar solo, whatever it is, great drummers know how to lead the band in. But you're right, the lead trumpet player has — there are times you know with different drummers if they get into something, then I start counting. I'm saying okay I want to make sure. But great drummers always lead the band in.

MR: Is there a discussion that would have happened back then when you became the lead player, did you ever discuss things off the bandstand with the drummer and the bass player about, you know we're not hanging together on this. Or is it just something that has to happen while you're playing?

MV: I think it's a bit of both. I don't think — the responsibility of the lead trumpet player is that you have to make sure things are going because in a professional situation if things aren't happening in the band there are times when the leader is going to blame the lead trumpet player. You know? And yeah there are times, especially with John Von Ohlen and John Worster that we talked about different charts and it wasn't like John was saying well Vax you're not coming in right, or I was saying well you're not leading. What we were discussing is how we made the chart feel better and sound better to the audience.

MR: A number of Basie alums have talked about how the Count was sort of a hands off — he didn't say anything unless something was really bad. And I wondered if Stan was like that or was he more hands-on and how did he deal with any, I guess I'll call them discipline issues?

MV: Well first of all Stan was very hands-on. And to play in that band you had to be 110% all the time. You know, the concentration level — I'll tell you — this is a great one. I don't remember when this happened but it was something where, you know any of the band leaders, they're basically going to play tunes from the last album and tunes that made them famous. And so they get into this thing of different tours you're going to play almost the same charts every night. You know. And sometimes the band is getting oooo — let's do something different. And this one time I remember Stan had been thinking

about it and as I said he was very hands-on. And so before this one concert he came in front of the band and he said, "The band is getting complacent and I don't like it." He said, "You guys aren't getting your charts up." You know you get to the point where you've got the charts memorized you know? You've got the order memorized and you've got the charts memorized. So he said, "Every person will get out every chart and read every note tonight." And you know what? The band sounded different. You know and so I would say he was very hands-on but you've got to remember almost everybody that ever played on that band said he was the best leader to work for. You know he was like a father to us. You know they called him the old man in the earlier bands, even though he wasn't that much older than them, but yeah he was — you had to be there. You had to be on top of things all the time and I can remember times when he wasn't happy with some people and he'd call them aside and say, "Hey man, you've got to be doing better." And it wasn't — it was never mean. It never felt like he was being mean. It felt like he was being the father figure, you know, taking care of the business of the band.

MR: What did your band manager duties entail? Were you in charge of booking motel rooms and all that kind of thing?

MV: Yeah. Yeah I had to book all the hotels. I had to collect all the money. I had to stay in touch with Harold Plant's office, that was the people that handled all of Stan's finances and money and stuff. If we were getting paid in cash you had to take it — there were a couple of different banks that we used where Stan had accounts and you'd have to take it. It was really funny because sometimes we'd be out for seven or eight, nine days without getting to a bank or anything and I'd have a whole bunch of cash with me and so I thought okay the safest way is I'm going to wear old clothes and I'm going to put all the money in a paper bag and then I'm going to go to the bank. And I used to do that. And every once in a while one of the tellers would look at me like is this guy a drug dealer or what? But I thought well that's the safest way to get to the bank. But you know and the other thing was that Stan, you always — Stan didn't take a salary. He was amazing. All the money went to the band. The road manager was expected to have a few thousand dollars on him in case Stan needed to take people to dinner or he needed to buy some clothes or whatever. But he didn't take an actual salary. And so yeah, I booked the hotel rooms, I did all of the financial stuff. I had to deal, when there were people who — buyers who were not being very nice I had to deal with that. Stan didn't want to deal with that. You know and when Stan was sick that first time in 1971 and he was gone for five months, Dick Shearer and I led the band and Dick led the music and conducted and I did all of the announcing and I still do all the financial stuff. And I literally had to verbally fight with people to get the money. The office, they had this whole thing down where they would send a telegram the day before saying we thought Mr. Kenton was going to

be able to re-join the band but the doctors want him to stay a little longer. Well it was all lies because you know we had to keep the band on the road for him. So I had to pretend that, oh gee I really did think Stan was going to be joining us but they just said at the last minute he can't. So then they would, a lot of times, especially clubs and things like that, they'd try to say well you broke the contract because Stan isn't here. And I'd say, "You sold out, we're trying to keep this band on the road for Stan while he's sick and you're sold out. You made money, don't give me that stuff about you know we broke the contract and you want to — a couple of places you know they'd given the 50% deposit and they wanted to not pay the other 50%. And I had to fight with them and all except one club, The Loser's Club — believe it or not it was The Loser's Club in Dallas, and that was a huge scene where the guy, you know he had sort of like his own little Mafia thing and he had these guys with guns and all that. So we're back there and Dick Shearer and I are trying to say, "You know come on, you sold out, we were here two nights, you sold out." Willie Maiden brings some of the bigger guys back in there and the guy's got his two thugs and Willie says, "Listen man, if this is going to be like back in the 30s, man, if you don't pay the band we're going to wreck the club."

MR: I think Willie Maiden would have had to bring some of the bigger guys 'cause he looked like —

MV: Oh yeah exactly. And that was the only place in the five months that Stan was gone that I didn't get the rest of the money. All the rest you know it was part of what my job was. Yeah as road manager there were times that I had to do some disciplining, especially when Stan was gone. Because when the cat's away the mice will play so to speak. And it's not like the guys were taking advantage but again, they were getting complacent a little bit and taking advantage. And there were a couple of times where I had to threaten to fire guys. I didn't actually fire anybody while Stan was gone. I had to fire some people other times where Stan, you know that was one of my duties. Stan said get rid of them. But I didn't have to fire anybody while Stan was gone. Everybody believed we have to keep this band on the road for Stan because we love him.

MR: Was there a union rule of a sort that you had to give like a two week notice either way — if a guy wanted to quit, two weeks, etcetera.

MV: Yeah, exactly. And that's only fair both sides. So that's what we would do. Or if there was some instance, there was only one instance I can remember where it was just a situation where the guy needed to be gone and Stan basically paid him his two weeks and sent him home and got somebody else.

MR: You probably know this, that I'll just use the Fredonia experience. You were probably only seven or eight years older than the guys that were juniors and seniors, who were in the college jazz band.

MV: Some of the guys in the band were the same age.

MR: Yes. That's my point. And I wonder if you knew back then that a lot of these musicians really wanted to be you or to be the tenor player or to — in other words they wanted to do what you were doing.

MV: Definitely. Definitely. And there were times when we needed somebody where we got them from a college, or most of the time was from the summer camps. You know there were guys like Dennis Noday that were hired from the summer camps. You know and Stan — age didn't matter to Stan it was how good you could play. When Gary Pack joined the band as a jazz trumpet player he was 19. And of course you know the stories, back in the 40s Buddy Childers and Art Pepper were both 16 when they joined the band and Stan had to sign papers to, you know, and the parents had to give permission for them to go on the road. And so definitely, and when we taught, you know 'cause three or four days a week we were in schools. I mean that's how the band kept on the road. And so the questions, a lot of them, would be, "What's it like being on the band?" And "How do we get on the band." And how do we get on any band. You know? And basically we'd say practice your butt off, be able to sight read you know, and then when opportunity comes you know I really think that while there is such a thing as good luck I think that the Boy Scouts motto is the most important thing which is "be prepared." If the good luck comes and you're prepared you'll be ready for it. And that's what I used to tell the students in the clinics and I still do. I still say yeah, there's not much work compared to when I was your age, now, especially. But for the ones that really care to work hard enough and really want it bad enough, there's still ways to do it.

MR: Did Stan explain his vision to — there was a number of wonderful writers that did charts for the group and I'm wondering how much Stan would give them instructions. Here's what I want, here's what I don't want, etcetera.

MV: I think he did both. I think there were certain writers like Ken Hanna — when I was on the band, Ken Hanna, Willie Maiden, Hank Levy, where Stan just let them pretty much have their own — because they knew what Stan wanted. I mean even you go back to the early writers, Pete Rugulo and Bill Russo and Johnny Richards, they all knew what Stan wanted. And yeah, a lot of times like with "Cuban Fire" which if I had to say even over the albums I'm on, probably my favorite Kenton album, Stan said to Johnny Richards, you know the Latin guys think that when we play Latin stuff it isn't real. They say it's not official. We've got to figure it out. And of course Johnny was Mexican. But he went and he hung with a lot of the Cuban musicians in New York. And he went and he hung with them and he listened and so when he wrote "Cuban Fire" and "Cuban Fire" came out, a lot of those musicians said Stan's got it. So I think that Stan did instruct Johnny what he wanted and it was basically I want the Latin musicians to accept what we're

doing. With Hank Levy's time charts, you know Stan — Hank Levy had played on Stan's band in the late 40s I think, played baritone sax and done a little bit of writing. But then of course later on got into a thing with Don Ellis with all the time charts and Stan decided, you know obviously before we did all those in the 70s when Stan recorded "Adventures in Jazz" with Johnny Richards, I mean amazing time charts. But we really got into it with public performance of time charts with Hank. And Stan pretty much gave him the head you know. And I think that basically another writer, Bill Holman, Stan and Bill Holman used to argue about tempos. Stan would usually want things faster than Bill Holman had thought of them in his head you know. But think of all the great music that Bill Holman wrote not only for the Kenton band but Basie and all these other bands. I mean Bill Holman's maybe one of the most prolific big band writers in history you know, he and Sammy Nestico and a few others. And so with Bill, Stan would sometimes — I don't think argue — but they would discuss exactly what he wanted. Because Bill came, Bill even talks about that he came from Gerry Mulligan and where he got all these contrapuntal ideas of writing really came from Gerry Mulligan. Gerry Mulligan only wrote six charts for the Kenton band and Stan didn't really like that many of them. Because you know back then you know in the early 50s those were all the great bebop players. And Stan used to say, "Listen, I don't want to be Woody Herman, man, I want to play my music." You know because they wanted to swing more you know. It's like there's an interview with Shelly Manne and he was asked, "What's it like playing drums on the Kenton band?" And Shelly Manne said, "Chopping wood."

MR: And this ain't the "Woodchopper's Ball" here.

MV: And then one time they were having some discussion with some of the musicians and Stan is saying, "I got certain ideas that I want this band to do and it isn't a matter of swing. It isn't a matter of coming from the old big band and the dance bands. It's a matter of being a concert jazz orchestra" And I guess this was on the bus or something and from the back of the bus Al Porcino, who always talked very slow, he said, "Why don't you try swinging?" You know but Stan, of all the leaders, Stan knew what he wanted. And if you think about it the Basie band of the 30s and 40s, the Basie band of the 70s sounds pretty much the same. It's the Basie sound. You think about how many times the sound of the Kenton band changed. And it was always Stan's vision going on to the next thing. He was always looking forward. You know? And so the stuff from the late 40s and then the orchestra that he took on tour in the early 50s and stuff, some of that stuff was just so far out the audiences didn't know what to do. You know like the recording of "City of Glass" and all that. And then all of a sudden he got through with that and you get to like the early 50s and a little bit later and it's the contemporary concepts and it's always just

stuff that, in the Kenton way, swings its butt off. You know I mean just the change was phenomenal.

MR: Speaking of swinging its butt off. Name this tune: are you ready?
[scats]

MV: Well that's "Intermission Riff" of course, yeah.

MR: Okay, so "Intermission Riff." Now how does "Yard Dog Mazurka" go?

MV: Almost the same. And Ray Wetzel swore that he did not copy "Yard Dog Mazurka." And it's funny you know but then if you think about it "Artistry in Rhythm" sounds almost exactly like Ravel's "Daphnis et Chloe." And Stan again swore that he did not take it from that. But you think maybe some years earlier he heard a recording of it and it went stuck in here. But like with "Artistry in Rhythm" it goes [scats] and "Daphnis et Chloe" goes [scats]. It's only one note difference.

MR: Nowadays we'd be in court over that.

MV: Probably so. But with "Intermission Riff" in the beginning there was no chart. It was a head chart. Ray just — they were just going to use it as a break tune so Ray just taught it to everybody. And then over the years more arrangements were done. And of course the arrangement that we play with the Kenton Legacy Orchestra that Kim Richmond did in the middle of it he voiced out Carl Fontana's whole trombone solo from "Kenton in Hi-Fi" he voiced out Carl Fontana's whole trombone solo for the whole band. So in the middle of "Intermission Riff" you have Carl Fontana's solo that the whole band is playing. You know so we have an even more updated version of it. But that's probably one of them that was played the most of anything with the Kenton band. That and "Peanut Vendor."

MR: Oh right. And we played that too of course, at Fredonia. I wanted to change subjects a little bit here and ask you about some of your recordings. There's one that goes back a ways, "Old Time Concert in the Park."

MV: Oh. The "Vaxuosity" CD.

MR: Yeah.

MV: That's with the Ohlone Wind Orchestra and that's an adult concert band that Ohlone College sponsors and over half of them were full time professional musicians. This band is just phenomenal. And Tom Johnson, who has been my recording person and sound person geez for twenty years or more than twenty years, thirty years, was teaching there in their recording studio. They had a big recording studio and he was actually teaching recording techniques. And he arranged it. I forget how it came about. I think we were just talking and he knew that my degree actually is in classical performance and he knew that I had done cornet playing and stuff, and so somehow or other we came up with this idea of doing something nobody had ever — the people that were fans of mine from Kenton or

Dukes of Dixieland or whatever, would sort of be surprised at. So we decided to record that. And one of the catalysts was that tune, "Vaxuosity," which Lieutenant Commander Phil Field wrote for me, the leader of the Navy band. And that was written for concert band. And so we recorded that thing over the course of I think about six weeks. We do a few tunes at a time and then I'd be on the road a little bit and then I'd come back you know. But a lot of that stuff on that recording, that band was just sight reading. They played it down once and then recorded it. They were phenomenal. And it was really fun because it was something I'd wanted to do all my life and it actually got done.

MR: Yeah, sort of stepping back in time you know, the concerts in the park with a picnic spread out and sort of nostalgia.

MV: And I actually played, the Oakland Municipal Band in Oakland, California had been in existence even back then for I think 150 years. It was one of the early bands. You know back in the 1800s and the early 1900s even little tiny towns had the town band. And that band would do concerts all summer long, and so this is a real American tradition, the concert band thing, from back in the, probably mid-1800s you know. And so the Oakland Municipal Band had been going a long time and I played a solo cornet with that band for quite a few years. So I was actually in that situation where you'd be on a beautiful bandstand, it was at Lake Merritt. The lake was right behind the bandstand. It was a beautiful gazebo, you know, big enough for about an 80-piece band. And you're right, the people that would be out there, there were no bleachers. I mean the people would sit on the lawn with their lunches and everything and there'd be a huge crowd. It was wonderful.

MR: Tell me about "Creepin' with Clark," and how that came about.

MV: Oh well the three biggest mentors in my life I said one was Don Jacoby and Stan Kenton and Clark Terry. And it was funny because we were playing Wichita Jazz Festival, I think this would have been 1970 maybe, and Clark's band opened for the Kenton band. His quintet. And so after the concert Stan and Clark are talking and Stan says, "I want to meet your lead trumpet player." I mean Clark says, "I want to meet your lead trumpet player." So Stan introduced Clark and I which became the friendship for the rest of the time until he passed away and he was a true mentor to me in so many ways, especially since he knew that I was doing clinics and stuff. And then in 1978 I played lead trumpet on his big band for the European tour and people say what's it like playing lead trumpet on Clark Terry's band. And I'd say it's like getting a trumpet lesson every night of the week. Because every night you're hearing him do stuff that you can't do on trumpet, it was just unbelievable. And of course Clark was one of the nicest people ever put on the face of the earth and he was one of the most important clinicians. He inspired so many young people. So I wrote this tune, "Creepin' with Clark," as sort of a joke. It's based on

"I Got Rhythm" changes with just a few minor additions to the changes. But the joke was that you're supposed to play it as fast as you can and I named it "Creepin' with Clark" because no matter what the tempo was it didn't matter to Clark. It was like nothing mattered to him, it didn't matter how fast you went. And so I wrote that tune in honor of him. So we had talked for quite a few years about oh wouldn't it be fun to do an album together. And we got an angel that put up the money and we recorded it at SONY Studios in New York City and I flew in and Reggie Thomas, the piano player, flew in, and it was Rufus Reid on bass who lived there, and Sylvia Cuenca who was Clark's drummer for years who lived there, and John Allred on trombone who had just moved to New York and Clark didn't know about John. Of course John Allred is one of the great trombone players. So we decided okay, we've got the money, we're going to do this. And we said we've got to record a lot of our own tunes. So we recorded some tunes that I wrote, we recorded tunes that he wrote and then he picked a couple of things like he wanted to do "Jive at Five" in honor of — oh come on it just went out of my head — oh Sweets Edison. And so we picked all the tunes. I think we had a rehearsal Friday night and then we recorded for two days. And of course the word got out so musicians were coming in the studio to see what's happening with the recording and stuff. And I have to say that one of the things that really gets to me, to his dying day Clark said — Clark was on over 900 recordings, believe it or not it's documented. And to his dying day he said that that recording was one of the favorite recordings of anything he'd ever done. We just had such a great time doing it. And the music came out wonderfully. And of course I channel Clark because he's been my mentor and my idol for so long, especially on flugelhorn. So there are times on that recording — in fact I'll tell you a great story. We were listening to playback of "Struttin' with Some Barbeque" which we did as a samba. And Rufus Reid was saying something to Clark and then we got back and we were listening and it's when Clark and I are playing fours. And Clark looks at me and he says, "Is that me or is that you?" And all I said was, "Thank you." But —

MR: Am I correct that you were at his bedside near the end of his life?

MV: Oh yeah. I was the party planner for his 90th and 94th birthday parties. And the 94th was just a few months before he passed away. And a bunch of the guys that had been on his big band, all of us came together and Stafford — what's Stafford's last name, I'm going to forget, the trombone player — oh darn — that played with Clark. Anyway he sort of worked on getting the musicians there. So we actually had enough, with adding some people, to get out Clark's big band book and we actually set up in his living room and played for him. And Clark, ever the educator, a couple of times he would stop the band, "No, no, no, no that's the wrong tempo" or something like that. "Do it this way." But yeah, we were with him just a few months before he passed away.

MR: Let me ask you about high notes. You have a way of talking about high notes are not necessarily higher, they're farther away?

MV: Right. And I learned that from Don Jacoby. You know it was interesting, Don Jacoby lived in Denton, Texas the last part of his life. And for 20 years every lead player in the One O'clock Band at North Texas had studied with Jake even though he wasn't on faculty. They would just go to his house for separate lessons. And his philosophy was that up here, it was here and it was here — you can't see my hand — but the air, the diaphragm. And that was it. Your mental attitude and the air that you use. And that was his quote. High notes aren't higher, they're just farther away. And when you can — he showed me how to do this and I've done it with young people where you put three music stands, each one a little farther away, then you have the wall, and you get a young kid to say okay I'm going to tell you what notes to play and like give them a triad like C-E-G-C. Low register. And you say, "Now you're going to aim at each one of these just like it was a laser beam that you can see leaving your horn." I added that part. And it's going to hit that music stand and then you're going to hit the next one. And it's amazing — there are many times in clinics with young students where I've gotten them to play a fourth or a fifth higher than they ever played before within a few minutes. Because the concentration and the thought that the air and the sound is moving away from you. And Doc Severinsen used to say, "I think that way, I don't think this way." You know? So the projection thing really helps. And I've been doing it for years and years but I didn't invent that, it was from Don Jacoby.

MR: Do you know Wayne Bergeron?

MV: Oh very well. What a great player, what a great guy, I mean he's just amazing.

MR: I want to read a brief quote from our interview. And there's not a question here but I just wanted to share this with you. He said, "When you're twelve years old and you can hit a double high C your ego inflates pretty fast. I heard Maynard Ferguson playing high notes on the end of a tune so I just played a high note on the end of everything. It didn't matter what the chord was, I just played a double high C because my friends were all going 'all right' and they'd high five me."

MV: I mean that's so true. And it's an interesting phenomenon I guess. There are some people, like Wayne was really a natural from the beginning. I was sort of a natural but I wasn't one of those guys that just had it when I was young. And I had to work really hard to get where some other trumpet players already were, you know in high school and stuff and junior high even. And so I just — I had decided probably by the time I was 14 or 15 I want to be a trumpet player. You know? Just I want to be a trumpet player. And so I had great teachers — Irving Korr, who was the solo cornetist in the Oakland Municipal Band way before me was my first teacher. Another teacher that was really important who is

still alive, Norm Tompach, who really got me into the jazz thing. He had written for Basie and Woody and he was the leader of the Fort Ord Army Band at one point. And so he was important and then in college Gordon Finlay, who'd been the solo cornetist with the Navy band in Washington for 20 years. I studied with him. And these people made me work. You know I practiced a lot and I practiced what they wanted me to. I didn't just sit and play tunes or whatever, although I did that afterwards. In fact even when I was young sometimes my mom would have to come in and stop me from practicing because they said, "You're not doing your homework. Do your homework and then you can play some more." You know. And so I think maybe that's one reason why I'm considered a good teacher because it wasn't just natural to me. I had to go through a lot of work to get to where I ended up. And so I can sort of impart that to kids because of what I went through.

MR: If you're playing two different charts and on one chart you have to end on a G above the staff, a high G, and it happens to be the root of the chord. And then the next tune you have to end on that same high G but in this case it's like it's a very thick chord, a 13 chord or something and your note is definitely not the root, is the second G harder to play than the first one?

MV: Harder isn't the right word. I hate that word hard in music because for kids it makes it sound like oh I can't do it, it's impossible. I would say it's more of a challenge, yeah. I would say that, and you know with the Kenton band a lot of the dissonance, a lot of that dissonance that was close together was in the trumpet section way up high. And so if I'm on that high G and the second trumpet player is on an F and the third trumpet player is on the D and the fourth trumpet player is on a B flat or something and you know you have to be sure — but the main thing is that you — playing a brass instrument is like being a singer. You have to hear the notes before you play them. A brass instrument isn't like a woodwind instrument. They have their own challenges. But on a woodwind instrument if you put a certain set of keys down that note is coming out. On a brass instrument there are no guarantees. You know it's here and it's the air and it's here and here [points to head and ear]. So another thing about — you were asking about lead trumpet, your ear has to be there. You have to hear the notes even before you play them. So and say that you've finished this big chart and there's an 8-bar drum solo and bam the last chord, you better know what that note is before you're going to hit it. And I think that it also has to do with feeling. I feel notes in my body. I can feel — not just here but in your whole body because you're using your diaphragmatic air, you're using your brain, you're using your ears. And so it's a matter of hearing and feeling the notes probably before you play them.

MR: Is that teachable?

MV: Yes. But it takes a student who wants to work hard enough. And what I tell students in the clinics is if you've got a hard lead trumpet part in like a shout chorus, and you want to really practice it and be able to play those notes and hit each one three times down an octave, one time where it's written, the intervals sound exactly the same. So what you're hearing in different octaves is the same notes. So why kill your chops? Three times down an octave, one time where it's written. And you use that as a way to practice if you want to do it quite a few times, then you're not killing yourself but this is hearing the intervals and it's hearing the placement of the notes.

MR: Sometimes I get the feeling that the surrounding sonority helps that note come out. I don't know if it's my imagination. It's like if I try to play a high note above the range on the saxophone and I tried it in the practice room I'm not going to get it but tonight when the band is playing around you I have a better chance that it might come out.

MV: I think that that helps. Yeah. I think, and part of the challenge of getting to where you can play that, especially for a lead trumpet player, is to be able to do it by yourself with no help. And then when you get with the band I agree with you, all that sonority and everything actually helps. But one of the things that, like on the Kenton band you know what they used to call that huge cymbal, the eliminator, that huge cymbal that Stan had for the band. You know why it was called the eliminator? It eliminated a first trumpet player's high G. It was something about the overtones in that. It could eliminate — and there were, like at the end of "Malaga" when he'd hold that high G forever and Von Ohlen's, "Boy you've got to get that note out because that cymbal is going to try to just eliminate you."

MR: That reminds me of a Joe Wilder story when I think he was on the Hampton band or something. They had this mythical thing called the barracuda that would get rid of things that they didn't like. I can just see someone losing that cymbal.

MV: Oh no, no, no. The band loved that cymbal.

MR: Oh no kidding.

MV: It was part of the sound of the band. One of the things that they did do one time, you know because back with the mellophone band with the Kenton band, those mellophones were out of tune. They were not great instruments. And there had been a mellophonium before with Conn but Johnny Richards and Stan went to Conn and I think the mellophoniums were in E flat but Johnny Richards wanted them in F and they fiddled with them and so the sound was amazing but they were not really very well in tune. And boy those guys had to work. And of course they were so loud. I mean they were louder than the trumpets or the trombones. So people were always trying to get rid of the mellophones and at one point I guess some of them ended up in a swimming pool in a motel. But that's not — the reason Stan stopped — the mellophone band I think only

went about 3-1/2 years. And it was basically the same as people ask me well with the Kenton Legacy Orchestra how come you don't have mellophones? Same reason Stan had to get rid of them. I've got to pay four more guys? Where am I going to get the money?

MR: Yeah. What did you guys do on the bus trips? This is pre-cell phones, pre-walkmans. How did you pass your time?

MV: Some guys read books. A lot of guys had some kind of a boom box but on the bus it was like you used earphones, you did not bug everybody else with what you wanted, unless it was something that everybody wanted to listen to. But yeah, people read books, people read newspapers, people listened to music a lot, and you know there were numerous, every day there were numerous discussions about — Stan — this was really sort of a funny thing. Stan was a very conservative guy. And of course a lot of musicians are very liberal. And he would go in the back of the bus and he'd start some kind of political thing and then these guys in the back would all be arguing and he'd come up to the front laughing his head off, "Look what I started." And there was a lot of discussion of music. Not just the music we were playing but music history, other bands, people that we liked listening to. So it was, you know you found ways to pass the time but you're right — you know kids today ask well what was it like being on a road band on the bus. We say well if there was an emergency you had to hope that there was going to be a small town coming up pretty soon on the highway and you had to hope that there was a gas station with a pay phone and you had to hope you had change.

MR: Wow. How primitive.

MV: You got it. There was no way to communicate, you know you're right, there was no way to communicate with the outside world. Being on a band bus was like living in a cocoon. And each person had their area, which was usually you know two seats. And everything they owned for the road was in that area and above. And it's like being on a road band is like being in a family. And the family gets along but sometimes the family doesn't always get along. You know? And it's, it's a cocoon, that's all I could say. You're stuck on this moving sphere, you know, for six, seven, eight hours a day, seven days a week. You know I mean, other than the summer camps which of course we loved because everybody enjoyed teaching but also we were in one place for six nights. But other than that if you had a gig where you were two nights in the same hotel, ooh. That was like wow look at this. This is great. You know? I'll tell you a great story, one time we had not had a day off in six or seven weeks. Seven nights a week on the road, all one nighters. We played some resort for two nights. And so the second day, unbeknownst to each other, all the trumpet players washed their horns out, which you don't do as much as you should on the road. Well that night we're cracking and we're cracking and Stan comes back, "What the hell is wrong with the trumpet section?" We said, "I don't know." And

we found out we had all washed our horns out that day so you got a different bore trumpet.

MR: You didn't have all that juice in there to play through. Wow. There's a quote here, someone saying, I think they're saying that you said this. It was in amongst the things you sent me. "Mike Vax reminded us all that being a great musician is far more important than being a great trumpeter. He exemplifies this concept with every fiber of his being."

MV: That was from, this is quite a while now, the first Westchester Trumpet Festival which was a big one. And I was the featured artist. It was an interesting thing because I had had throat surgery I think three weeks before and they didn't cut me, they went through, but I had nodes on my vocal cords. I was starting to sound like Miles, man. You know and I couldn't talk very loud. And so for two weeks I couldn't talk and I couldn't play. So I had a week and I just got myself back together as much as I could and I told the promoter of the festival, I said, "I'm probably not going to play too many high notes while I'm there." And he said, "You mean you can actually come?" And I said, "Yeah the doctor doesn't like it but he said, 'You can come.'" So I get there and I did the last clinic. We'd done a couple of concerts with some really good trumpet players and stuff. And then I did the last clinic of the festival. And I've always professed that for somebody who really wants to play the instrument is not what's important, the music is what is important. And I don't care whether you're a violin player or a piano player or a trumpet player or you play kazoo, you know you've got to get past the instrument. Too many players, especially trumpet players, let's face it, our egos are terrible. So too many trumpet players it's the high notes man and it's loud and how fast can I play on this solo. You know, and there's got to be a reason why Chet Baker was so famous. It had to do with music you know. And I mean you take the complete opposite ends, say Chet Baker and Maynard Ferguson. But if you heard Maynard play a ballad, or you heard Maynard play a jazz solo that was just amazing, you know that recording of Maynard and Clifford Brown and Clark Terry with Dinah Washington. I don't know if you've heard that but she actually got them to play on a recording session. They were all around the recording studio. And Maynard is right there with Clark and Clifford, I've got to say. And Maynard, I remember an interview with Maynard when somebody asked him about screech trumpet playing, because that was the title back then.

MR: Screech.

MV: And he hated that word. He said, "I'm not a screech trumpet player, I'm a musician." He said, "I don't care how high I'm playing I'm trying to play music." You know? And that stuck with me. And again, for classical players you know you hear some classical players who are just phenomenal technically and it doesn't move you at all. All the notes are right, but there's nothing else. And so to put your personality, and in classical music you

can't change it around like you can with jazz, but there has to be some of you in what you play and there has to be more than just the notes on your instrument. So I always profess that what you strive for is to be a great musician not a great player.

MR: Did you know Joe Wilder?

MV: I know of him. I didn't know him.

MR: Yes. When you said that about putting personal expression into classical music it made me think of him because he did that. He could do that. Well this has just been a fascinating conversation, and I wonder, to wrap up, if you think back to when Stan and a few of the others sort of launched jazz education, could you envision what now in 2022, what the business of jazz education has arrived at? The state of it now?

MV: You know it's interesting, the original National Association of Jazz Educators, the original one, was basically Stan's idea. And they were at I forget if it was Midwest or they were at one of the big conventions and the Kenton band had played. And I can tell you some of the guys that were there: Leon Breeden, Gene Hall, Jack Wheaton, Herb Wong, Matt Benton. They were in Stan's suite and they were bemoaning about there's no jazz at these conventions. There's nothing going on what are we doing, and basically get off your butts and start something and get it going and what a lot of people don't know is Stan put up the original money. He said, "We have to get this —" and Stan was, one of the things with the Kenton Legacy Orchestra that we say is we are not trying to be the Stan Kenton Orchestra, we are carrying on his tradition of jazz education and creative music. He believed that if jazz was going to survive you had to get to the young people. Because how else — forget more musicians, how are you going to have an audience? If young people aren't being exposed to it how is there going to be an audience in another ten, fifteen, twenty years? You know? And so he really believed, and he was the first band leader to bring his band into schools on a regular basis, and from that Maynard did it and Woody did it and even Basie a little bit. But he was really the first one to get that going and of course with the national stage band camps which became the Kenton summer camps, Ken Morris was the administrator of those and had come to Stan and said, "I want to start summer jazz camps and I want you to be the resident band." And Stan jumped at it immediately and so they formed, the first one was 1959. And then I went to the one in 1960 and it was at Indiana University. And of course it blossomed out into where they were doing five or six every summer. You know? And so I think that what has happened in schools, it's sort of going backwards a little bit I'm sad to say but you know during the 60s and 70s, 60s it was getting started, 70s it got strong and 70s 80s, even into the 90s, it was really strong. And even before Covid I hate to say it but as you said I'm outspoken, too many young band directors have gotten to the point where the trophy is the most important thing, not teaching the history of the music or teaching a

love of the music. It's how many trophies do we have in the band room. And so they'll rehearse three, four, five tunes over and over and over all semester so they can go and win trophies. And that's not education. It's not what Stan envisioned, it's not what most of us in jazz education envision. And one of the things that when I do, sometimes I'll do a clinic at a state convention for the educators. And I'll say, "How many of you actually delve into the history of jazz music with your students? How many of you play old recordings for your students?" Rehearsals aren't just about learning the tunes to go to contests. Rehearsals have to be part of making these students love the music. If you don't know the history of the music how are you going to have a love for it? And so many young people, I mean it's gone even farther now but a few years ago we were doing it young people would think that like Coltrane and Charlie Parker were like traditional jazz. They had no idea about what went on in the early part of the twentieth century in New Orleans and Chicago and San Francisco and New York and Kansas City. No idea. They barely know the name Louis Armstrong. You know? So what I tell the band directors is you know you've got the greatest thing to use right now and that's the Internet. You know? You can go on YouTube and you can see people who died fifty years ago playing a concert. So on your — I can't say blackboard anymore because the boards are all white now you know, say on your white board every week put a name. And your students have to google that name and they have to listen on YouTube and they have to go to Wikipedia and have them write a one paragraph thing about that person. And you know the band directors that have done it have said to me, you know, the students get a new — I don't know maybe love of the music is wrong — but a new interest in the music because now they're finding out where they came from. You know? I mean Gordon Goodwin writes wonderful charts but that's not where big band music came from. And if all the band director does is mainly play Gordon Goodwin charts, and I've got nothing against Gordon at all, but why don't they play some Basie charts? Why don't they play some Kenton charts? Why don't they play some Woody Herman charts? And if they were doing that at their concerts you'd be surprised how many of the parents and grandparents would say oh wait a minute, I remember that tune. You know? But I think that the education and the history has to be taught and it isn't just about winning trophies.

MR: That's well said, and I can't think of a better way to wrap up here. Congratulations on your career.

MV: Well thank you. I've been very lucky you know. I'm now 80 and still playing and we're planning a tour for the Stan Kenton Legacy Orchestra next April in the Midwest. And I'm crazy enough to try to keep it going.

MR: Yeah I think a little crazy helps.

MV: Yup.

MR: Well thank you, Mike, and you look forward to seeing yourself on YouTube eventually with this interview, and it's just been a real thrill for me.

MV: Well listen I'm happy to do it. And it's interesting because when Nick Mondello and I were talking about you he said, "He's going to have interesting questions, much more interesting than a lot of people who interview." And he was exactly right. Now this has been wonderful, I've really enjoyed it.

MR: Thanks a lot. I'll see you on the flip side somewhere.

MV: Great.